

Responding to youth experiences of climate change

A guide to the feeling-thinking-behaviour archetypes

Purpose of this guide

This guide supports practitioners, educators, and program implementers in applying the Climate Change Feeling-Thinking-Behaviour Archetypes. The archetypes describe diverse ways young people feel, think, and act in response to climate change. It is intended to support reflection, inclusion, and engagement, helping young people feel seen, heard, and understood.

How the archetypes were developed

The archetypes draw on climate and youth mental health research and over 3,000 responses from Mission Australia's 2023 Youth Survey, linking how young people feel, think, and act in response to climate change. They were refined through youth co-design workshops, where participants validated and expanded the typology to capture adaptive responses.

Using the archetypes

The archetypes can be used as tools for conversation, reflection, and program design. They can be introduced in classrooms, workshops, counselling sessions, or youth consultations—any setting where young people are encouraged to share their experiences of climate change.

Some key ways to use them include:

- **Conversation tools:** Start discussions by asking participants which archetype, or combination, feels most familiar to them at the moment.
- **Reflection tools:** Use archetypes as prompts for journaling, storytelling, or group reflection (e.g., photovoice, dialogue circles).
- **Program design:** Identify which archetypes are most represented in a group and tailor activities or support accordingly.
- **Monitoring and evaluation:** Track shifts in archetype patterns to understand changes in engagement or wellbeing after a program or campaign.
- **Co-design and adaptation:** Involve young people in adapting, renaming, reframing, or creating new archetypes to better fit their context.

Applying archetypes across sectors

Sector	How the archetypes can be used	Example use case
Education	Integrate archetypes into classroom discussions or wellbeing programs to help learners express their feelings.	A teacher uses the archetype cards: "Which of these emojis feels most like you right now?"
Mental Health Services	Use archetypes as conversation starters or reflection tools to explore climate change impacts.	A clinician or counsellor invites a young person to identify an archetype and discuss what helps them cope.
Youth Engagement	Use archetypes in workshops to recognise starting points and co-design inclusive climate activities.	An organisation maps participant archetypes before a project to ensure activities engage meaningfully.
Communication & Advocacy	Tailor campaign messages to reflect the diversity of archetypes rather than assuming everyone feels the same.	A campaign features quotes from each archetype, helping young people feel seen and heard.

The Climate Change Feeling-Thinking-Behaviour Archetypes

The represent patterns expressed by young people when describing how climate change impacts their feeling, thinking, and behaviours. The archetypes are not fixed identities or linear stages. Young people may identify with more than one archetypes, and these may shift over time or in response to life events, context, and new information. Archetypes reflect diverse ways of responding to climate change, and none is more valid than another.



Hopeless Helper

"I try to do what I can, but it feels like nothing will change."

Feels powerless about systemic failures but still tries to act individually.

- **Feels:** Hopelessness, sadness, frustration.
- **Thinks:** Systems (e.g. governments) are failing, and I can't change them.
- **Does:** Make small personal or lifestyle changes (e.g. recycling) to cope.



Nervous Navigator

"I don't even know if I want to have kids anymore."

Feels anxious about the future and reconsiders life choices.

- **Feels:** Anxiety, fear, worry.
- **Thinks:** Climate change is an immediate, existential threat to our future.
- **Does:** Change major life plans (e.g. family, career) or avoid thinking ahead.



Furious Fighter

"I'm angry at how little our leaders are doing! We need to fight back."

Feels anger at inaction and channels it into action.

- **Feels:** Anger, frustration, determination.
- **Thinks:** I see injustice and systemic failure. We must act urgently.
- **Does:** Engage in activism, advocacy, or awareness-raising.



Guilty Guardian

"I feel responsible for what is happening. I try to make better choices."

Feels personal guilt and sadness and tries to compensate.

- **Feels:** Sadness, guilt, disappointment.
- **Thinks:** I am personally responsible for environmental damage.
- **Does:** Try to reduce carbon footprint or live more sustainably.



Wounded Witness

"I feel paralysed watching everything fall apart. It's impossible."

Feels deeply distressed and overwhelmed, leading to functional impact.

- **Feels:** Despair, hopelessness, no meaning.
- **Thinks:** Catastrophe is inevitable. Life goals are pointless.
- **Does:** Withdraw from planning and/or experience impaired daily functioning.



Detached Drifter

"I used to worry, but it's easier to just tune it out. Nothing changes."

Feels numb or disengaged after repeated disappointment.

- **Feels:** Apathy, resignation, fatigue.
- **Thinks:** Nothing will make a difference. There is no point in making a change.
- **Does:** Withdraw from action and avoids climate news or discussions.

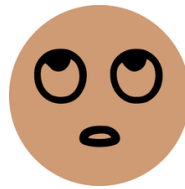


Determined Doer

"I want to be part of the solution. Doing something helps!"

Feels hopeful and empowered through solution-focused action.

- **Feels:** Hope, purpose, motivation.
- **Thinks:** Collective action and small steps can make a difference.
- **Does:** Participate in climate projects, advocacy, or peer education.



Curious Observer

"I'm still figuring out what's really going on and how I can help."

Approaches climate change with curiosity and a desire to learn.

- **Feels:** Interest, concern.
- **Thinks:** Climate change is complex, but solvable. I want to understand it.
- **Does:** Seek information, listens to insights, engages in learning and dialogue.



Cautious Skeptic

"I am not sure whether climate change is really a big problem."

Acknowledges climate change, but questions narratives and solutions.

- **Feels:** Uncertainty, independence.
- **Thinks:** The problem exists, but media or politics exaggerate some aspects.
- **Does:** Selectively engage, preferring practical approaches.



Carefree Camper

"Climate change is a big issue, but I don't really stress about it."

Stays positive and enjoys life while being lightly aware of issues.

- **Feels:** Calm, contentment, acceptance.
- **Thinks:** Worrying won't help. I want to enjoy life.
- **Does:** Focus on everyday life, small acts of care, or community connection.



Reflect

- When you think about climate change, which of the following archetypes best matches you? You may pick up to three.
- Do you notice certain archetypes emerging in particular situations? What seems to influence or trigger them?
- How might help people who relate to different archetypes work together or support each other?
- Is there a way you experience or climate change that isn't reflected in these archetypes? If so, please describe.

Principles for using the archetypes

When using the archetypes, apply them ethically, collaboratively, and with care:

1. **Non-labelling:** Archetypes are tools for understanding, not identities to assign. Avoid stereotypes or assumptions; they are descriptive, not prescriptive.
2. **Reflection before intervention:** The goal is to surface experiences, not to correct them. Archetypes can then inform supportive, youth-led co-design.
3. **Context sensitivity:** Archetypes may shift over time and across contexts. Recognise that responses are dynamic and shaped by environment and experience.

Climate Change Feeling-Thinking-Behaviour Archetype Badges

These can be printed as badges to help young people name their climate experiences and recognise how these shape their actions. Each distinct archetype hopes to make abstract experiences more tangible and create an entry point for reflection, discussion, and understanding.



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